Shipley Capture Manager
PLAYBOOK™

A Path to Winning Business





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Shipley Capture Manager Playbook™

"Winning business in today's competitive markets requires discipline and know-how. Professionals pursuing business in any market segment need to be assertive in understanding and assessing customer needs, competitor positions, and strategic solutions.

The Shipley Capture Manager Playbook *provides a step-by-step approach and necessary tools for capture or opportunity managers to qualify for and win strategic opportunities. The* Playbook *identifies key milestones and decisions that are necessary to advance the sale and gain a competitive advantage. Dismissing key steps or just assuming a favorable position with the customer is a formula for failure. By applying the key tasks, activities, milestone decisions, and tools found in the* Playbook*, you improve your probability of winning.*

Like any documented process or best practice, it is only as good as your ability to execute. Good luck as you pursue opportunities to build your business future."

-Brad Douglas, President & CEO, Shipley Associates

Understanding the Sales Cycle

With input from hundreds of companies in dozens of industries, Shipley has established a well-accepted, baseline business development lifecycle framework. This framework consists of these phases:

- Market Identification and Segmentation
- Long-Term Positioning
- Opportunity Assessment and Qualification
- Opportunity/Capture Planning
- Pre-Proposal (Bid) Planning
- Bid and Proposal Development and Submittal
- Post-Submittal Activity and Execution

Figure 1 highlights the phases of business development and progression on which the *Capture Manager Playbook* focuses.



Figure 1. The Shipley Business Development Lifecycle. *The seven phases are an efficient basis to understand and develop a successful framework for your organization. The phases addressed in this* Playbook *are highlighted above.*

A lifecycle is a progression through multiple stages leading to a desired result. For this *Playbook*, that means winning more business. In business development, the lifecycle is not just about winning any type of business, but business that is sustainable and profitable—business that helps the organization meet objectives.

Shifts in the market and internal changes require that the business development lifecycle be agile and flexible. Organizations must adapt—and do it quickly—if and when market conditions change.

This *Playbook* focuses on capture planning, the phase leading up to bid/proposal planning and proposal development. It also addresses activities, tasks, and milestones that set the groundwork for this phase. The S*hipley Business Development Lifecycle Guid*e provides a detailed description of each phase and step in a fundamental business development lifecycle.

The Role of the Capture Manager

As mentioned previously, the *Playbook* includes sections on the business phases before capture planning. Sections 1 and 2 focus on these preliminary phases, which are generally carried out by senior business leaders or other upper management. Understanding the prework for capture planning is necessary to successfully fulfill your role as a capture manager.

During the capture planning phase, a capture manager prepares information for decision gates and color team reviews. Once management makes a decision, the capture manager executes the outcome management has approved.

Because a capture manager performs certain tasks and supports others, each capture manager has both primary and secondary responsibilities.

Primary responsibilities

- Leading all opportunity and sales activities
- Managing the capture process
- Developing the opportunity/capture plan
- Forming the core pursuit team
- Determining and prioritizing customer hot buttons and issues
- Assessing competitive position
- Determining discriminators, win strategy, and solution set
- Initiating teaming agreements and small business plan, as needed
- Actively participating in key decision gates
- Scheduling WIN party

Secondary responsibilities

- Assisting proposal writers/managers in organizing the proposal team
- Collaborating on proposal planning and development—help craft the sales message
- Ensuring price, management, and technical volumes are consistent
- Responding to customer questions
- Assisting executive officer in customer negotiations
- Helping program manager transition to contract execution

At each stage of the process, the capture manager accomplishes many steps that advance an opportunity for others on the team. Managing the opportunity process, as shown in Figure 2, increases the chances of winning business.

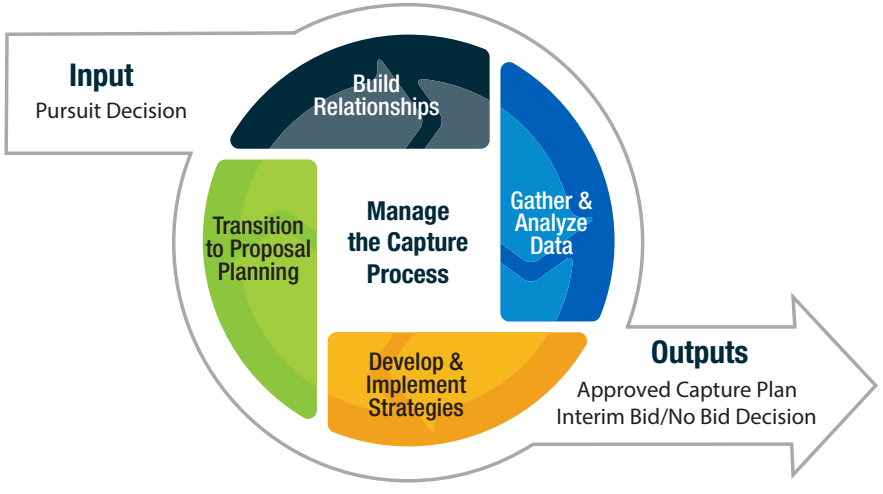


Figure 2. Capture Planning. *Capture/opportunity planning is vital for a successful business development lifecycle. When you have a successful and reusable process, you are better positioned for winning business consistently.*

Decision Gates

The capture manager is actively involved in key decision gates. Decision gates are milestones in the business development process tied to your evolving understanding of the customer's position in the buying cycle.

At these milestones, appropriate levels of executive management decide whether to advance a business opportunity to the next phase or end its pursuit. The decision gates are designed to eliminate sales leads or opportunities from your pipeline that you have a low probability of winning, permitting greater focus on opportunities that can be won. Figure 3 illustrates some of the key decision gates of a pursuit.

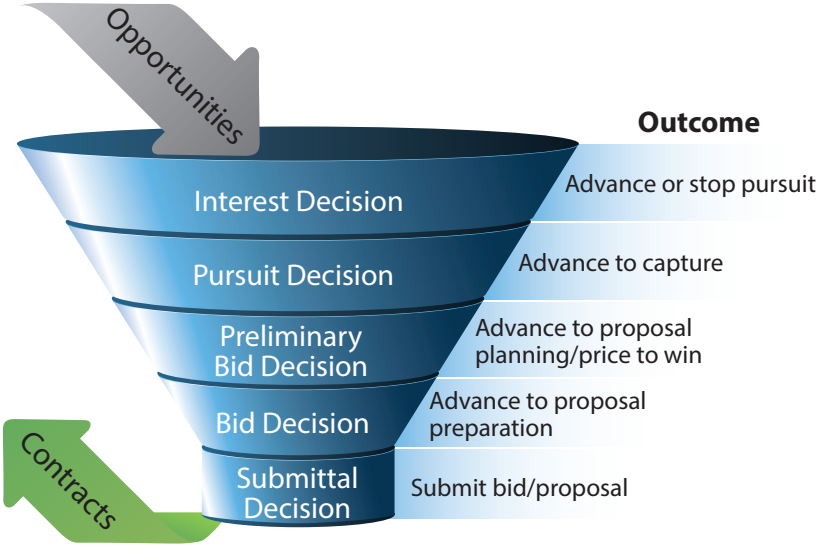


Figure 3. The Opportunity Decision Gate Funnel. *The goal of a rational business development process is to eliminate opportunities with poor strategic potential or low win probability. Organizations that eliminate poor opportunities early in the process actually increase total revenues. Win the most important contracts by concentrating your resources on more strategic efforts.*

See Decision Gate Reviews in the *Shipley Capture Guide*.

The Capture Manager Tools

Accompanying the *Shipley Capture Manager Playbook* is a compilation of simple-to-use, industry-tested tools to help manage and improve the capture management process. These tools are Microsoft Office-based and easily customizable to your organizational needs and culture.

A list of tools is included in the back of the *Playbook*. You will also receive a link to download (one-time) these tools for your personal use.

The following two icons are your guideposts for key milestones and tools to use throughout the *Playbook*:



Key Milestones: These are critical steps in the management process; be sure to address each of these key steps.



Shipley Download Tools: These are titles of tools that are included in the *Playbook* toolkit that apply to the associated step.

How to Maximize the *Playbook*

The *Shipley Capture Manager Playbook* is a one-stop shop for activities, tasks, milestones, and tools to effectively lead and manage a strategic pursuit in any market environment—Business-to-Business, Business-to-Government, international, or grant opportunities.

Capture and opportunity managers can follow these steps, adhering to the key decision gates and milestones, to win more business.

Each section of the *Playbook* discusses key decisions (decision gates) that must be made by senior management before advancing to the next opportunity gate. These decision gate reviews bring discipline to the role of the capture manager. Follow this discipline and you'll not only win more, you'll be much more efficient.

The *Playbook* helps you achieve five primary goals:

1. Assess your competitive position in the market to determine your probability of winning (Pwin)
2. Strengthen your position and readiness to provide a competitive solution to the customer
3. Determine real discriminators of your company or solution through careful SWOT analysis (Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities, Threats) associated with the opportunity
4. Develop win themes to communicate why your solution is unique and better than competitor solutions
5. Establish a go-forward plan for winning the business

There are four primary sections of the *Playbook* followed by capture checklists, a list of tools, and a glossary of terms. The *Playbook* also references in-depth information on various topics in the Shipley best practice guidebooks and links to a variety of simple Microsoft Office tools to help accomplish proposal objectives.

Section One: Opportunity Identification

Opportunity identification encompasses your efforts to identify customers with opportunities you might decide to pursue and bid. You establish a presence in the marketplace and attempt to positively shape potential customers' perceptions about you and your capabilities. You identify and investigate many opportunities, with the goal of separating one from the crowd that matches your strategic direction and capabilities.

Section Two: Opportunity Assessment/Qualification

Opportunity assessment includes research about the opportunity itself, looking for information on requirements, schedules, funding, and so forth. It includes research about the customer, who they are, what their preferences might be, who they prefer to work with, and about potential competitors and their positions with the customer. Your tasks during opportunity assessment compare details about the potential contract with your business direction and capabilities. During this phase, you are looking for information on whether developing a capture plan is justified.

Section Three: Opportunity/Capture Planning

Capture planning embodies your efforts to influence the customer to prefer your solution before a solicitation is written or released. You work collaboratively with the customer to craft a solution, addressing not only explicit requirements, but underlying hot buttons. You develop and lead the customer toward acceptance of a solution that discriminates you from your competitors. You gather intelligence about the customer and the competition.

The ultimate goal of capture/opportunity planning is to advance the sales opportunity toward closure—to make it easier for the customer to buy from you. By applying these principles, steps, decision gates, and tools, you have a better opportunity to move from an "unknown position" with the customer to a "favored position" because you've done your homework, as shown in Figure 4.

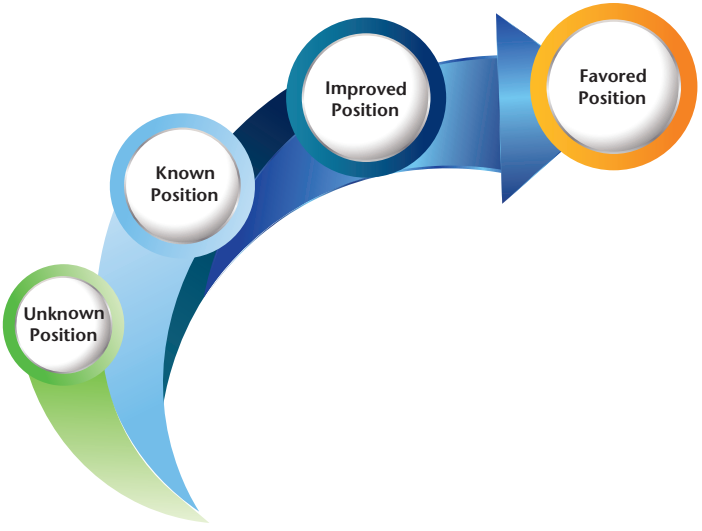


Figure 4. Capture Management Goal Targets a Favored Position with the Customer. *Effective capture management often begins with your organization in a relatively unknown position with the customer. Through research on the customer, the opportunity, and potential competitors, you can establish a known position. Through development of an appropriate solution, strategy, and price, you can advance to an improved position. Successful implementation of action plans can help you achieve and maintain a favored position.*

Section Four: Supporting the Proposal

A well-conceived and executed capture plan prepares the company for the next step: writing a successful proposal. Your goal should be to arrive at final solicitation release in a favored position with the customer, with winning baseline solutions in technical, management, past performance, and cost or price areas, and with internal commitment on strategies to follow. You must pass all that information on to the proposal team. Supporting the proposal team ensures everyone has the same information and is working toward the same goal.

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Supporting the Proposal

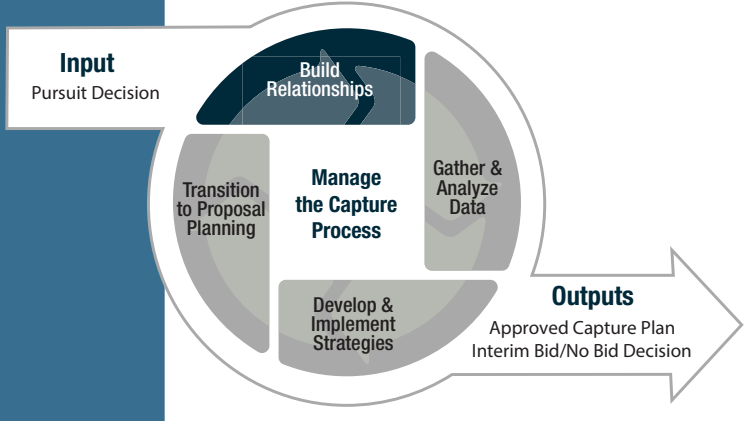
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Opportunity Identification

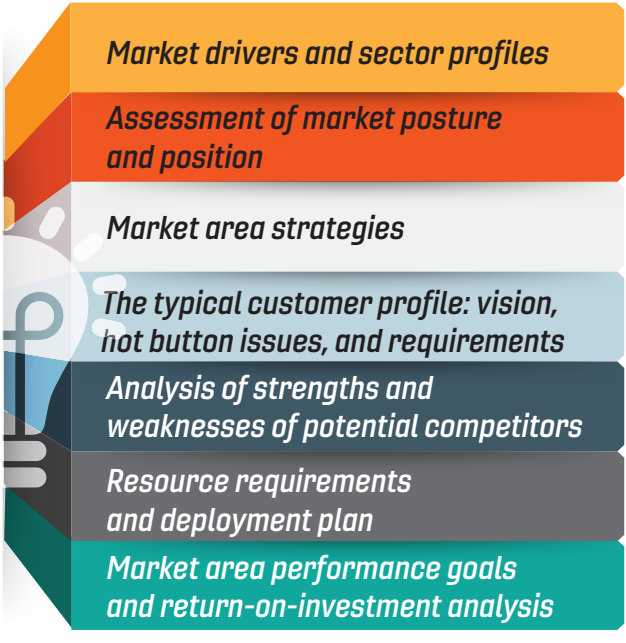
Opportunity identification activities establish your place in the market, influence potential customers' perceptions, and help prospect for business opportunities.



Notes:

1-1 Develop and align marketing and campaign plans

Business development leadership is responsible for making sure the marketing strategies and plans align with campaign plans for specific pursuits. Consider the following aspects of a marketing plan as it evolves to become your campaign plan:



Leadership must be aware of campaign plans in various markets and provide input where appropriate. Without proper alignment with marketing or campaign plans, a capture effort is likely to fail.

Leadership should adjust the plan as they obtain new information, review the plan often to incorporate new intelligence, and realign the plan with your organization's strategic plan.

1-2 Establish criteria to prioritize new business opportunities and build customer relationships

Prioritize the new business opportunities required to reach strategic goals and objectives outlined in campaign plans or company strategic plans (see Figure 5). Consider these factors:

- Potential for additional business
- Product, market, and technology match
- Return on investment
- Fit to strategic business plan objectives
- Corporate risks and chances of success
- Knowledge of the marketplace, competition, and competitive environment
- Projected long-term business conditions
- Market costs and costs of winning business
- Resource commitment for the capture effort and program execution

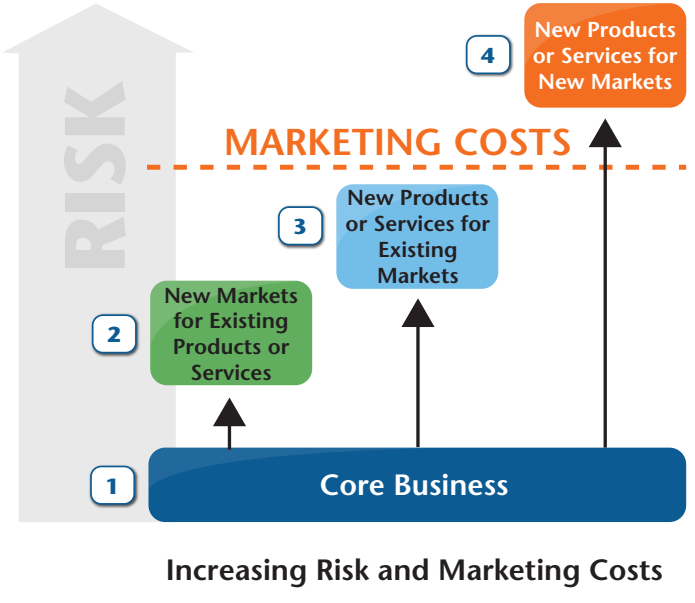


Figure 5. Avenues to Increase Revenue. *Creating any new business can include many marketing costs. The more unfamiliar the product or market, the more risks and costs associated. This image illustrates the increasing marketing costs associated with market, service, and product expansions. The numbers align with the numbered sectors listed in Figure 6.*

New business opportunities classified as strategic or must win attract more attention within an organization. Given the four opportunity sectors shown in Figure 5, Sector 1 opportunities are usually the most winnable and least risky.

In Sectors 2–4, a new customer relationship must be built. Even with existing customers, introducing a new offering demands a redefined relationship. The business development team must establish or modify these relationships while implementing new positioning strategies.

SECTOR	CHARACTERISTICS	PURSUIT INDICATION	EARLY ACTION	RISK
1	Similar product or service, similar market	Strong	Focus on competitors	Low
2	Same product or service, new customers	Moderate	Learn market, establish presence	Moderate
3	Similar customers, new product or service	Moderate	Verify needs of customers	Moderate
4	New product or service, new customers	Weak	Create detailed plan, commit resources, revisit your strategic plan	High

Figure 6. Choosing Opportunities. *Be realistic when branching out from your core business. Opportunities in Sector 1 automatically carry a strong pursuit indication. Sector 2 opportunities should be weighed against your emerging view of the new market and the success you have had establishing your presence. Sector 3 lead considerations should concentrate on verifying needs of the unfamiliar customer. Sector 4 ventures demand detailed planning and inevitably consume more resources before a new customer can be influenced to purchase something you have little history selling.*

See Introduction to Capture Planning in the *Shipley Capture Guide*.

1-3 Prepare interest decision recommendation

The interest decision might be the most important decision gate in business development. Once approved, an interest decision acquires momentum and is increasingly difficult to terminate at subsequent pursuit and bid decision gates. Reviewers in many organizations lack the will to say "No" and lament prior approvals. "No" must be acceptable. "Yes" implies an alternative opportunity is not pursued.

Identify specific potential opportunities, projects, programs, or purchases. Figure 7 shows a list of questions for evaluating an interest decision. For each opportunity, identify the purchase cycle, decision makers, budget, and other opportunity-specific information.

Opportunity	✓ Is the opportunity real and funded? ✓ Do we know the potential customer's perception of us?
Fit	✓ Does this opportunity support our strategic, annual operating, account, or marketing plans?
Positioning	✓ Does the customer know we are considering this opportunity? ✓ Are we an incumbent? ✓ If not, have we been actively calling on the customer?
Customer Mission	✓ Do we thoroughly understand the customer's mission?
Competition	✓ Do we know who potential competitors are likely to be? ✓ Can we team with a competitor if necessary? ✓ Are there alternatives to our likely solution?

Figure 7. Interest Decision Gate Review Questions. *Consider these questions when preparing for or attending an Interest Decision meeting. Add your own to this checklist whenever they make sense. Delete those that don't apply to your company or market opportunities.*

Discard opportunities with low win probability or poor strategic potential so time and money can be focused on more promising targets.

If opportunities meet the qualification criteria, prepare to present your analysis and recommendations to senior management at the Interest Decision Gate review. Mandatory and optional inputs for this review should be predefined and aligned with your qualification criteria. Typically, larger, must-win opportunities will have more rigorous briefing input requirements.

1-4 Make interest decision and assign lead for opportunity assessment

The objective of the Interest Decision Gate review is to verify that the opportunity fits your organization's strategic direction and capability. If approved, management authorizes additional research to assess the opportunity—or opportunities—and the activities to position your organization and potential solutions.

If the interest decision is positive, management assigns a lead individual to complete or manage the in-depth opportunity assessment.

The title of this lead individual might be account manager, sales director, marketing specialist, territory manager, or another title, depending upon the organization.

Milestone

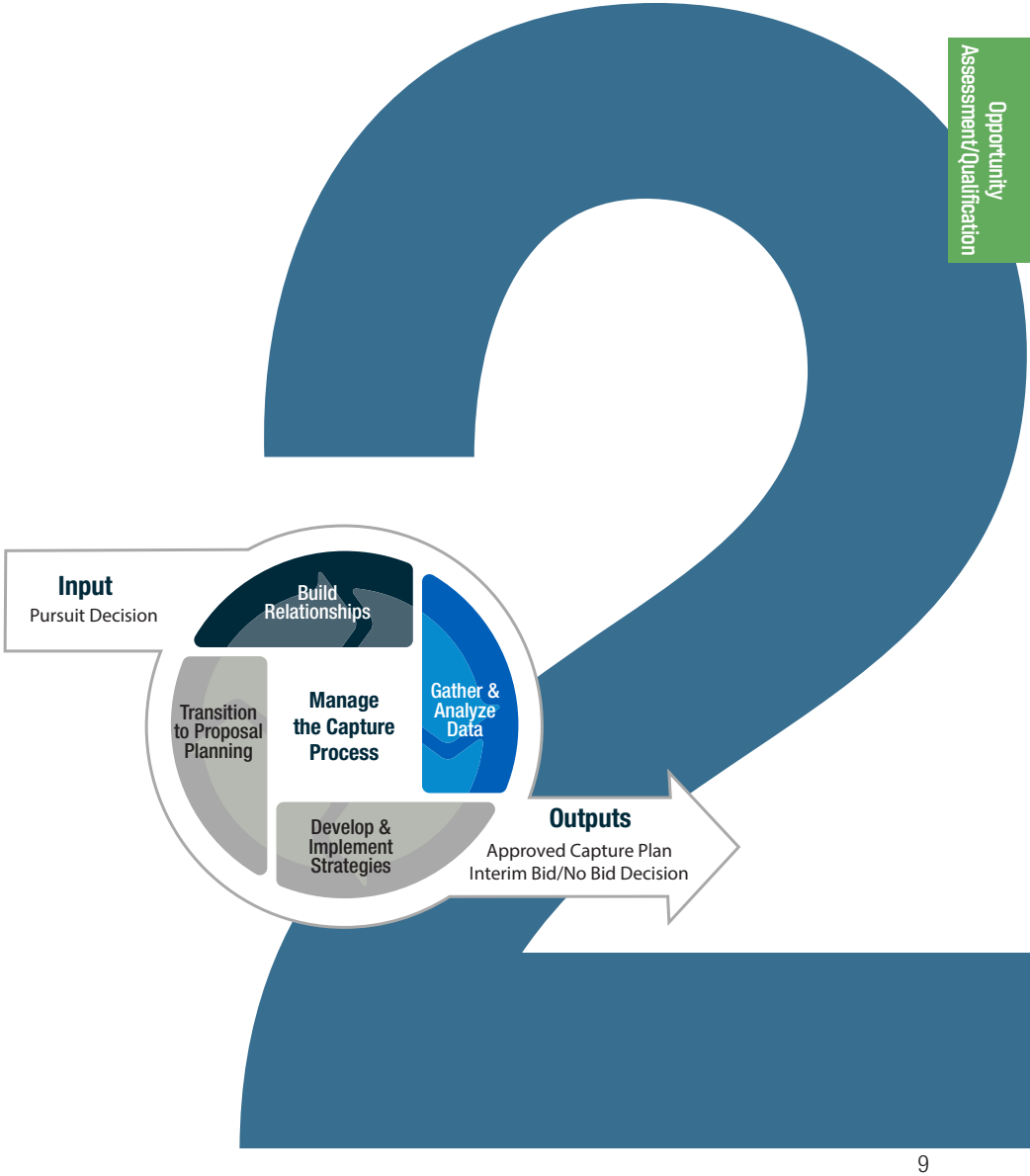
- Interest Decision Gate Review

Refer to Appendix A for Interest Decision Gate Review questions.

Notes:

Opportunity Assessment/Qualification

Opportunity assessment builds knowledge of the opportunity, the customer, and the competitive environment to support a decision on whether to begin an active pursuit. The capture manager is often assigned after a positive pursuit decision.



Notes:

2-1 Gather preliminary customer/program intelligence

Many sources help you gather information on customer and program opportunities. These may range from personal relationships to the news, websites, or annual reports. Additional information sources are featured in Figure 8.



Figure 8. Gather Information from Multiple Sources. *To effectively prepare a pursuit decision, you must get to know the customer. There are multiple ways to learn about and cultivate a relationship with the customer that range from personal connections to information found online.*

Successful intelligence gathering requires that you:

- Listen to the customer
- Ask good questions
- Determine customer issues
- Provide feedback to demonstrate that you understand the customer's needs
- Identify the decision maker, potential budget, funding source, buying and evaluation process, funding status, and customer's view of you and your competition

If you do not have the opportunity to meet with the potential customer in person, there are many other sources you can use to gather information and identify opportunities. Figure 9 lists some research resources.



Figure 9. Research Resources. *Many companies feature information about themselves through online platforms.*

2-2 Participate in industry briefings and other meetings

Participation in industry briefings and meetings is essential to demonstrate interest and is often mandatory to be able to submit a bid. Carefully target these intelligence-gathering and positioning opportunities, select appropriate people to attend, and then strategize your approach to each event. Use a template like the Customer Meeting Planning Form to help you strategize.

Exploit industry days, pre-bidders conferences, and similar events as a valuable forum to build customer relationships, network with potential teaming partners, and gather competitive intelligence. In this step, the marketing team determines the attractiveness of individual opportunities for pursuit.

Customer Meeting Planning Form

2-3 Cultivate initial position with customer

Begin to work with the customer by positioning yourself as capable of understanding the customer's needs, helping them define requirements, and potentially providing an acceptable or preferred solution.



Capture management, marketing, and technical personnel cultivate customer relationships by collaborating with the customer during visits, giving presentations on technology and capabilities, issuing white papers, and inviting customer decision makers for site visits and demonstrations.

Build a relationship with your target customers. Repeated, positive, and predictable contact with potential customers fosters further access to key decision makers and influencers and helps you build a trusting relationship.

Leverage social media channels appropriate to the customer's policies and preferences. All of these "touchpoints" are valuable when trying to establish a known or favored position with the customer.

2-4 Understand customer requirements and hot buttons

Validate your understanding of the customer's needs and requirements. This may require going deeper than just requirements. Discover what drives the requirements, what needs exist, and what may motivate the customer to buy. Customer motivators often stem from issues, or the problems that keep them up at night.

Where a customer's issues overlap their motivators, they become their hot buttons, or important issues likely to drive decisions (see Figure 10). These are often items the customer repeatedly discusses. Discovering and addressing hot buttons are essential to understanding customer requirements. Along with hot buttons, identify the technical requirements, management requirements, deliverables, preferred schedule, awardable budget, and the type and sources of funds.

Often, hot buttons also include unspoken, unwritten, or hidden issues. These are underlying issues that the customer has in mind that are only identified through discussion and dialogue with the customer. The capture manager should seek to identify underlying and hidden issues throughout the process of capture planning and strategy development.

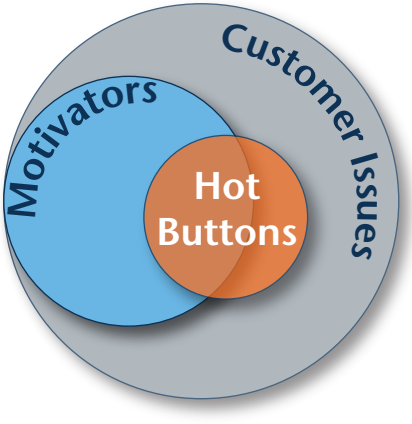


Figure 10. Issues, Motivators, and Hot Buttons. *Issues can be anything the customer worries about. Motivators are the main objectives the customer wants to achieve. Hot buttons are the most important factors that will swing the customer's selection decision to one offeror or another.*

Make sure there is a business case to advance the opportunity. Consider the business case for both the customer and your organization. Begin to develop and quantify the value proposition for both organizations. While you might pursue an initially unprofitable opportunity due to the longer-term profit potential, most opportunities must be profitable individually to secure capture planning funding.

2-5 Assess probable competitors

Research likely competitors on each pursuit. Use a variety of sources to learn about competitors and their likely solutions, strengths, weaknesses, and gaps. Sources of competitive information can include websites, industry events, bidders' conferences, subscription contract tracking services, employees, and other sources.

The Bidder Comparison Chart (BCC), shown in Figure 11, guides you in listing customer issues, hot buttons, and requirements and assessing your solutions against those of your likely competitors. This tool helps identify your own strengths and gaps—always using the perception of the customer as your guide.

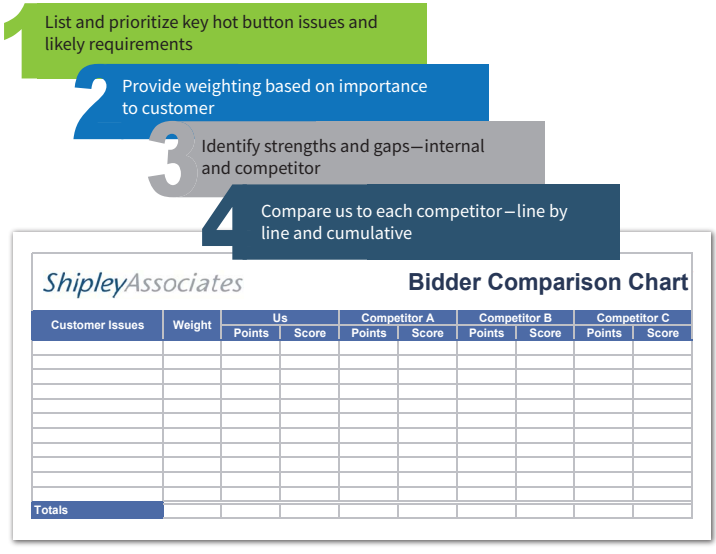


Figure 11. The Bidder Comparison Chart Guides Competitor Assessment. *Use the BCC to identify competitors' likely solutions to customer issues. As you learn new information about competitors, update and refresh the BCC to help evolve your win strategy for each opportunity.*

If this is a re-compete in the U.S. federal market, consider making a Freedom of Information Act (FOIA) request of the winning proposal and contract for the previous two competitions. Even if you are the incumbent, determine who might seek to regain their prior contract. FOIA requests might take up to 6 months to obtain, so start early.

Your employees can also be a strong source of information about competitors and their likely solutions. Assess as many sources as possible to allow you to compare your strengths and gaps against competitors using a Bidder Comparison Chart.



Bidder Comparison Chart

2-6 Analyze business fit, competitive potential, and initial competitive pricing range

Review what you have learned about the customer, market segment, and competitors. Decide if you are adequately capitalized and staffed to pursue, capture, win, and execute an opportunity (see Figure 12). Decide if the opportunity aligns with corporate strategic goals. Even if moving into a new market or creating a new customer is in the strategic plan, does it make sense? Can you afford to lose? Can you afford to win? A template like the Probability Calculator can help you make this decision.

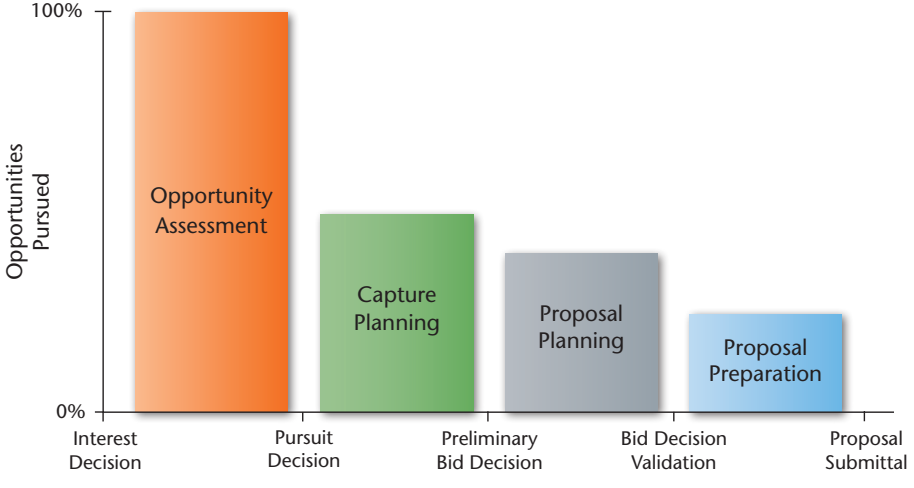


Figure 12. Selecting the Best Opportunities. *After the initial affirmative opportunity assessment, repeatedly reassess whether to continue to pursue each opportunity at successive decision gate reviews. Unaccepting customers, superior competitors, insufficient budgets, and poorly written proposals are valid reasons to cease pursuit. The notional percentage of opportunities allowed through each decision gate review depends on characteristics of the market, company objectives, and quality of business leads. The most successful organizations often submit proposals on a smaller percentage of the opportunities identified. Establish criteria for each decision gate review in advance, or discipline will fail and resources will be wasted.*

Build and repeatedly update your competitor, competitive, and price-to-win analysis knowledge base from publicly available, legally, and ethically obtainable open-source information. If you are uncomfortable with the source, do not use it.

Probability Calculator

2-7 Prepare pursuit recommendations

The focus of business development activities in the Opportunity Assessment phase are two-fold:

- ✓ **Analyze the customer, competitors, and yourself relative to the specific opportunity or set of opportunities.**
- ✓ **Estimate the resource and investment requirements needed to win, with emphasis on the upcoming capture planning phase.**

Base your pursuit recommendation on the business fit, competitive analysis, priority of other business opportunities, and availability of resources.

Provide unbiased, objective information. Do not oversell or undersell an opportunity to your leadership. Consider profit potential, pursuit resources, win probability, positioning for future work, and opportunity cost of not pursuing other opportunities.

2-8 Make pursuit decision and assign capture manager

Answer these questions at the Pursuit Decision Gate review:



If answers to these and other questions are vague or negative, further assessment of the opportunity is recommended **BEFORE** advancing the pursuit to the next stage.

Except for a do-not-pursue decision, the primary output of the Pursuit Decision Gate review is to name the capture manager and initiate the development of the capture plan. While the individual who first identified the opportunity is often placed in the capture manager role, this is not always the best choice. Perhaps the marketer or account manager cannot be spared from continuing marketing or sales activities.

The capture manager directs the capture team, including the program manager and proposal manager, further distancing them from their full-time job of selling and developing business. In addition, the capture manager role is often not a full-time position, but the time requirements tend to increase as the opportunity progresses.

Milestone

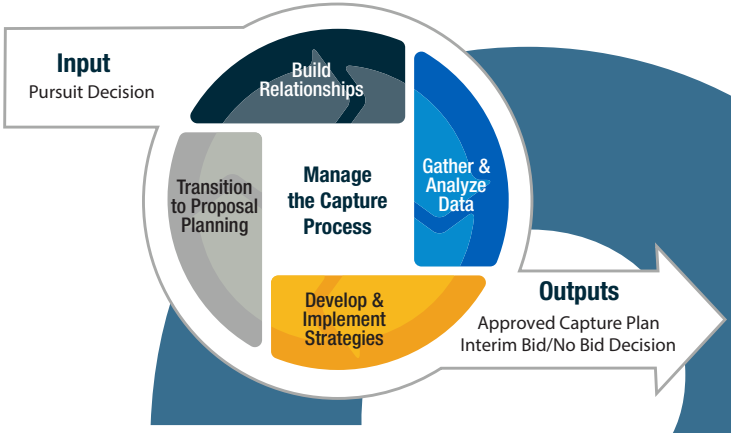
- Pursuit Decision Gate Review

See Capture Team Selection and Management and Decision Gate Reviews in the *Shipley Capture Guide*.

Notes:

Opportunity/Capture Planning

Capture planning focuses on preparing and reviewing the capture plan and then implementing winning strategies to influence the customer to prefer your solution. Successful capture planning requires documented, action-oriented plans.



Notes:

3-1 Establish capture core team

Begin by selecting and naming the core capture team. Note that the capture manager, program/project manager, and proposal team designations are roles—not necessarily positions—and these roles are often part-time depending upon the size and maturity of the opportunity.

The size of the core team reflects the complexity of the opportunity and the size of the proposal. The core team on a small opportunity might be one person working part-time. On larger opportunities, the capture manager often must fill the program and proposal manager roles unless other individuals are identified and assigned to those roles.

Figure 13 shows an example of a notional significant capture team organization on a complex pursuit. The designation of a capture manager implies a capture team will be formed. As the capture plan is developed, individuals will be added from internal functional departments and potentially from teaming organizations.

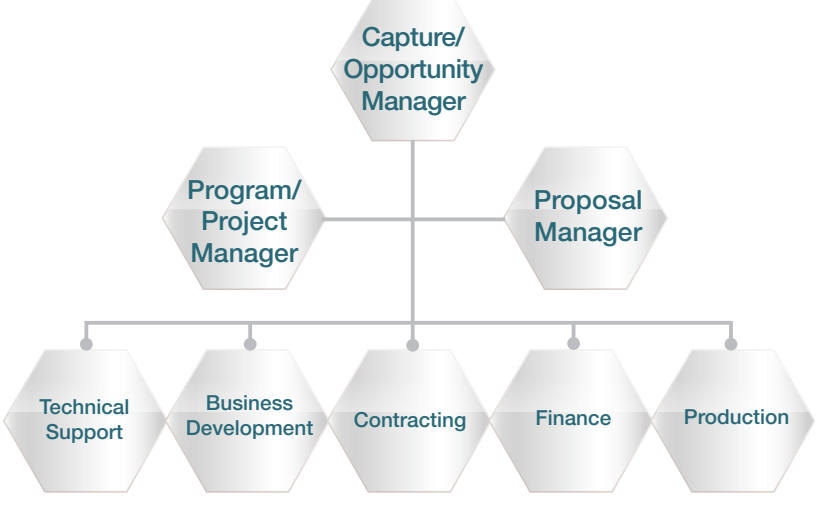


Figure 13. The Business Development Opportunity Team. *Win rates improve when the capture, program, and proposal manager roles are balanced and integrated. Notionally, the program manager owns the solution—typical when selling services. When the solution involves complex technical systems' design and development, a technical lead might join the program manager on the capture core team.*

Functional areas that should be included during the capture planning phase are shown at the bottom of Figure 13. Capture team size and scope vary considerably depending on the duration and complexity of the pursuit. Adjust the team as appropriate.

3-2 Extend customer contacts

Throughout this phase, senior management and the core team try to get as much information from their customer contacts as possible.

Depending upon the selling environment, customer contacts are often restricted, so contact, meet, and collaborate as early as possible. The earlier and more collaborative your efforts, the greater your understanding of and potential influence on the customer's requirements. Often government customers are willing to share information, but they worry about perceptions of favoritism. Business-to-business customers are generally more open to ongoing discussions.



Opportunity/
Capture Planning

Learn as much as possible about your customer and individuals in the customer organization before contacting them. Customers are impatient with bidders who fail to do their homework, seeing them as time-wasters.

Review your business development and marketing database, account plans, lessons learned reviews from prior programs with this customer, and publicly available data on the web.

Throughout the pursuit, customer contacts should be identified with their roles in the decision making progress. To the extent that you create your win themes and messages toward the needs of each customer or stakeholder, you improve your probability of win (Pwin).

3-3 Gather opportunity intelligence and analyze data

A capture team has no substitute for good program intelligence. The more the capture team knows about the customer's needs, key issues, and biases, the more persuasive your capture planning positioning activities will be. Ask key questions before the bid request is prepared, requirements are defined, and solicitation is released.

Appendix A features a checklist of typical business intelligence questions. Add better, more specific questions as you gather the program and customer intelligence required to initially prepare and repeatedly update your capture plan. Review the account plan, if available, and your capture template. Determining what you do not know is often more important than what you know.

As you gather new information from your customer, update and refresh the Bidder Comparison Chart. Use a template like the Integrated Solution Worksheet to help develop your solution.

Keep all information current and visible to the pursuit team so win strategies can be adjusted, as needed.

Refer to Appendix A for Interest Decision Gate Review questions.



Integrated Solution Worksheet

3-4 Initiate capture strategy and plan

Capture Strategy

The most important elements of the capture plan are your capture strategy and the associated tactical actions that your team will take to implement that strategy. Your capture strategy should be imbedded in the capture plan. Balance your capture strategy by focusing equally on your technical, management, and pricing approaches. Too often sellers focus on technical and management aspects, ignoring pricing or treating it as a costing issue.

Capture Plan

Within the business development planning process, the capture plan is the first plan focused on a specific opportunity target. Most focus on a single opportunity, but some focus on linked opportunity targets.

The capture plan details exactly what you will do to capture the business. It must be concise and specific, stating who will do what and when they will do it. Objectives should be specific and quantified, if possible, so progress can be assessed regularly and adjustments made.

Capture plans are living documents. To support collaborative activities and simplify repeated updates, capture plans might be in text, presentation, or web-browser formats. Web-browser formats offer significant advantages:

- Data is easy to collaboratively develop, share, and document in a single location.
- Senior managers can easily monitor progress, updates, and activity.
- Most contributors have a collaboration tool installed as an organizational standard.
- Security on these tools is relatively robust.

Capture templates are seldom completed in order because information does not become available in the same order. Use capture plan templates to prompt you to seek relevant data. As the customer moves toward release of the bid request, information will change and become more specific.

Capture plans are the basis for the proposal management plan and subsequent proposal efforts. The capture plan is shared with the proposal team to align capture strategies and tactics with supporting proposal strategies and tactics.

A simple approach for developing and executing a capture plan is shown below in Figure 14.

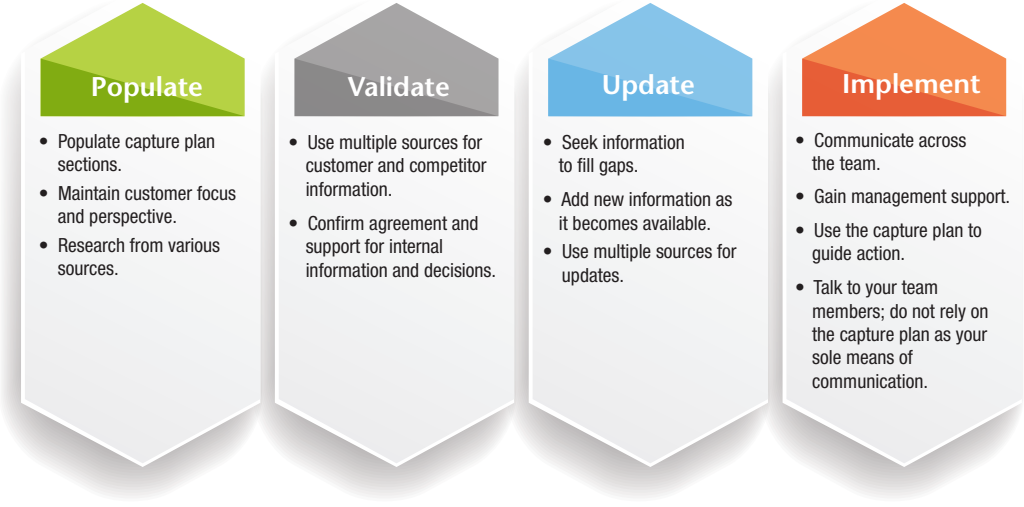


Figure 14. Iteratively Develop Your Capture Plan. *Keep your capture plan current and correct by repeatedly updating the content. Populate—complete what you think you know; validate—check and confirm; update—add and correct data; then, implement.*

There are many effective formats for a capture plan. Because there are so many aspects of the plan, the data is difficult to collect in a single document. All elements of a plan often reside in a CRM (Customer Relationship Management) tool.

Elements of a capture plan typically include:

- Customer Overview
- Opportunity Overview
- Internal Capability Assessment
- Competitor Assessment
- Bidder Comparison
- Win Strategy, including discriminators
- Strategic Positioning
- Action Plan (thorough)
- Action Plan Schedule
- Draft Executive Summary

Capture Plan Template
Opportunity Planner Template

The capture plan is the central tool used in the capture planning phase and is the basis for gate review briefings and decisions. Briefing from a current capture plan eliminates the need to prepare separate briefing materials.

The capture planning process should align with the ultimate goal of capture management: achieving and maintaining a favored position with the customer. Certain activities, listed in Figure 15, move you closer to this goal.

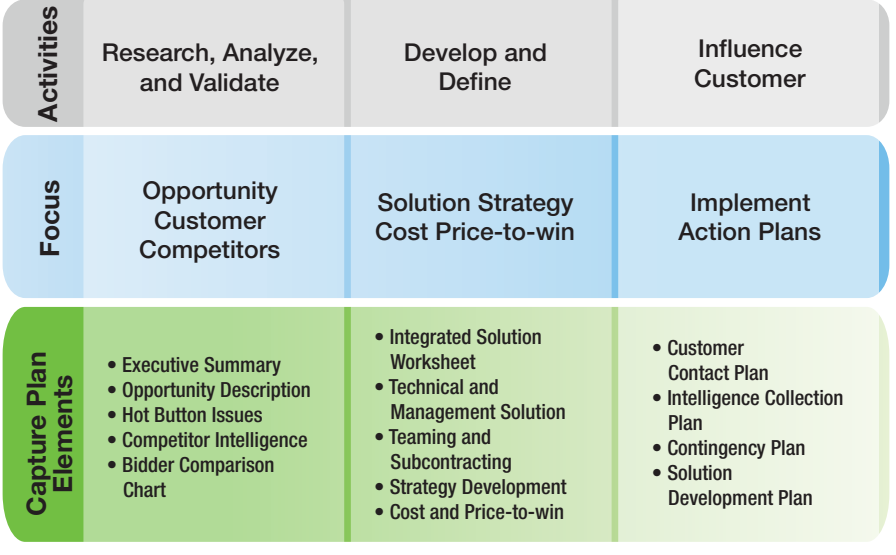


Figure 15. Elements of a Capture Plan. *Managing a capture plan involves many different focuses and steps. Some potential steps and elements are listed above. Specific content of your capture plans will vary depending on the opportunity, your organization, and the value of the opportunity to your organization.*

3-5 Develop capture budget

A positive pursuit decision includes the explicit approval of capture planning expenditures. However, you need to prepare a complete capture planning budget, which may include proposal preparation costs. Capture costs might include:

- Research and development
- Positioning visits to customer
- Demonstrations
- Advertising and recruitment
- Time for telephone calls, faxes, letters, and e-mail
- Search for teaming partners
- Internal briefings, management reviews, and white papers
- Monthly status/progress reports preparation and delivery
- Travel

Proposal costs might include:

- Planning resources
- Design or engineering development
- Customer demonstrations
- Internal and external presentations
- Proposal development personnel, facilities, and equipment
- Production and reproduction
- Oral proposal preparation and rehearsal
- Language translations

Most capture managers establish initial capture planning and proposal preparation budgets based on historic costs associated with the value of the opportunity. Adjust your initial budget according to the probable buying schedule, capture tactics planned, and resources available for the pursuit.

Note: Many costs are hidden. Be sure to plan for contingency costs as you evaluate your budget.

See Costing in the *Shipley Capture Guide*.

3-6 Prepare capture plan/win strategy for win strategy review (Blue Team review)

Developing a win strategy involves determining your discriminators.

A discriminator is a feature or benefit of your solution that is important and valuable to the customer and unique to you. A useful tool for establishing discriminators is a SWOT analysis (Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities, and Threats). This SWOT analysis should be done based on customer perceptions of you and likely competitors. A typical SWOT looks for strengths and potential gaps in solutions, as shown in Figure 16 below.

Using the SWOT analysis, you can establish a win strategy that highlights your strengths, mitigates your weaknesses, and subtly draws attention to competitors' gaps or weaknesses (without mentioning them by name).

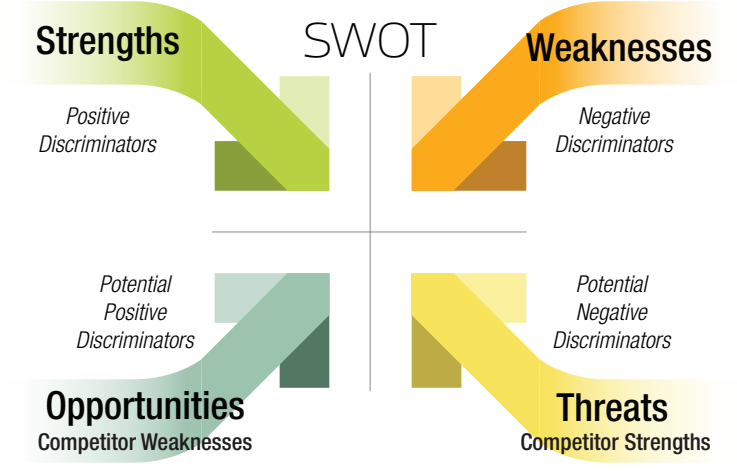


Figure 16. SWOT Analysis Helps Develop Discriminators. *The win strategy places focus on our competitive advantages and highlights these for the customer.*

Although capture managers make all necessary preparations for a Blue Team review, they are preparing this information for senior business development leaders who will lead the review.

Schedule a Blue Team review of your draft capture plan and win strategy. The Blue Team reviews the initial capture plan to evaluate your knowledge of the customer and opportunity, provides guidance on your potential solution, and recommends strategic actions you can take to position your organization as the customer's preferred choice. Figure 17 provides an outline for a Blue Team review. From this point forward, the capture team should follow the agreed-upon win strategy unless evidence surfaces that it is not making you competitive.

Organizer	✓ Capture Manager
Team Members	✓ Independent Blue Team Leader ✓ Business development management ✓ Operational management ✓ Experts on customer ✓ Product/service experts
Other Attendees	✓ Capture manager ✓ Capture team
Documents	✓ Pursuit Decision package ✓ Initial capture plan
Possible Approaches	✓ Structured presentation ✓ Individual review ✓ Facilitated discussion ✓ Brainstorming

Figure 17. Planning and Executing a Blue Team Review. *The capture manager assigns Blue Team members with a view toward obtaining valuable advice on win strategy, including feasible solutions. The more perspectives represented, the better the outcome is likely to be. Thus, customer, technical, operational, and business development experts should be included. The team will consider preliminary intelligence, shaping future directions of the capture team.*

Ideally, Blue Team members and the team facilitator are independent of the capture team and knowledgeable about the customer, customer needs, likely competitors, competitors' solutions, and your organization and solution.

Figure 18 lists desired outputs. Schedule a second Blue Team review if the Black Hat Team review (see 3-12) prompts you to significantly modify your capture strategy or solution.

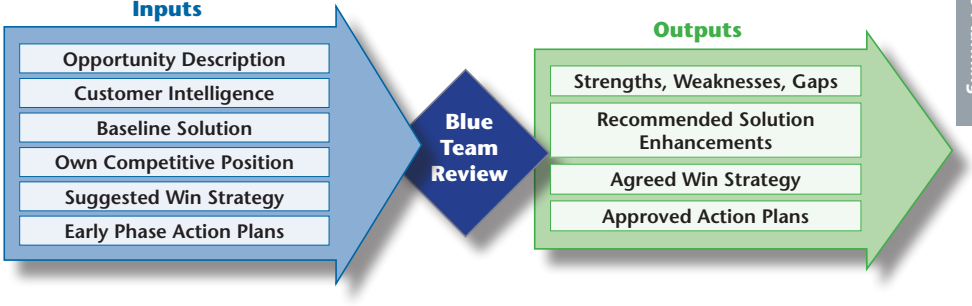


Figure 18. Blue Team Inputs and Outputs. *Blue Team members identify strengths, weaknesses, and gaps, and recommend improvements. They affirm the early actions of the capture team or advise them on modifications to their plans. They do not allocate or withdraw resources; the capture manager and executive team will make those decisions later.*

Milestone

- Blue Team Review

Blue Team Instructions
Blue Team Planner
Blue Team Review Form
Blue Team Assessment Form

See Color Team Reviews in the *Shipley Capture Guide*.

3-7 Refine capture strategy, action plans, and initial pricing strategy

Capture planning is an iterative approach. The capture manager—with support from the capture team—manages implementation and adjustments to tactics, evaluates feedback, and assesses progress.

Teaming strategies, pricing strategies, and potential price-to-win targets must also be refined and revisited as the capture manager learns more about the competitive landscape, customer budgets, and budgetary constraints.

3-8 Analyze customer needs and requirements

During the pursuit, the capture manager communicates as often as possible with the customer to understand needs and identify specific requirements, including hidden requirements. What is the customer's specific mission or buying vision? What are they trying to achieve?

When you clearly understand the customer's needs and specific requirements, you are more likely to be on target with your proposal and win strategy.

3-9 Collaborate with customer on potential solution

One of the most powerful positioning activities on any pursuit is collaboration with the customer. Through collaboration, you can better identify, understand, and validate customer hot button issues and requirements while pre-selling your solution. Collaboration builds the customer's confidence in your organization and solution, and improves your competitive position.

Avoid surprising your customer with new or undesired solutions. Most customers perceive new or unsolicited solutions as higher risk than the solutions that are developed collaboratively. When competing for government contracts, collaboration and communication with the customer often become limited or restricted at certain points in the acquisition. The capture manager must honor these restrictions and limits to maintain a strong customer relationship.



Action Plan Template

3-10 Update competitive pricing range

Capture teams should not develop solutions in isolation, but in conjunction with pricing specialists. Early in a pursuit, a preliminary price to compete helps place evolving solutions within a range the customer can afford. That range is bounded on the low side by the minimum price the customer finds credible and on the high side by the customer's addressable budget for the procurement, i.e., the amount the customer can pay after allocating necessary management and overhead funding.

Customers generally define—or can be helped to define—a minimum acceptable capability. Similarly, they seldom buy a solution beyond the maximum justifiable capability. Together, these price and capability limits define a winning price window: the region of a price and capability trade space that bound the customer's notion of best value.

Figure 19 illustrates how the conceptual winning price window narrows over time as the customer's understanding of needs, available solutions, and funding improves.

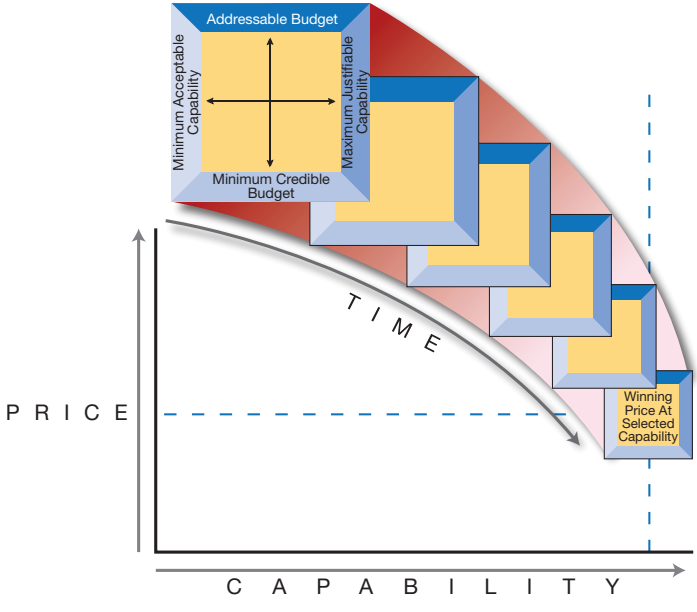


Figure 19. Winning Price Window. *The winning price window narrows over time as customers learn their needs and what budgets and solutions are available.*

As your capture team collects and analyzes competitive intelligence, develop and iteratively refine a price to win—considering not only the customer's winning price window, but competitors' likely offers. To develop estimates of competitors' positions in the winning price window, consider their probable capabilities, strategies, and tactics. Focus on competitors' prior, successful strategies, as they are likely to repeat successful strategies. Pricing-to-win professionals maintain that focusing on competitors' prior strategies is more predictive and useful than focusing on their prior rates and exact bid prices.

In U.S. federal procurements, the Federal Acquisition Regulation (FAR) defines two best value options: lowest price technically acceptable (LPTA) and trade-off process. If LPTA is used, then your solution set should be marginally technically acceptable at the lowest price and margin that you can accept.

Note that a price to win does not exist in isolation and is always an intersection of price and capability.

3-11 Make preliminary make/buy decision and initiate teaming/subcontractor agreements

Cost, capability, and quality depend upon the source, whether from internal or external resources. If internal, determine which division or location. If external, identify the vendor, subcontractor, or teaming partner. When working with external resources, determine if you want an exclusive relationship and their degree of involvement in the capture planning effort. Figure 20 lists make/buy and teaming considerations.

FACTOR	CONSIDERATIONS
Enhance team strength	Offset weaknesses; add capabilities or discriminators; add key personnel; current reputation with customer; small, disadvantaged, minority, or economic development zone business status to meet customer-restricted bidding requirements
Complementary roles and responsibilities	Avoid duplication of roles; conflicts with other contracts; potential; work shares for proposal and program
Augment capture capabilities	Agree on lead; sell integrated team; political influence
Enhance intellectual property	Guidelines for information and technology transfer
Logistics implications	Travel; co-location; technology standards; archives; compatible processes, values, and systems
Mutual protection	Binding legal and nondisclosure agreements; termination provisions; financial contributions; risk assumptions

Figure 20. Teaming Considerations. *Teaming decisions are important and often have repercussions beyond the immediate opportunity. Weigh the factors and implications when choosing partners and reaching teaming agreements.*

The first consideration listed is critical. The capture manager must validate that prospective teammates are preferred or at least acceptable to the customer and anticipated evaluators. An early decision gives you more time to influence the customer's view of teammates and your entire team.

The earlier you can make these decisions, the earlier you can bound your cost, price, and capability trade-offs.

See Teaming in the *Shipley Capture Guide*.

3-12 Conduct Black Hat review

A Black Hat review focuses on the competitive position based on competitive information and analysis.

Black Hat Team members are experts on the customer and competitors. They try to anticipate competitors' strategies and solutions and test the soundness of your strategy and solution.

Black Hat Teams prepare capture plans for each major competitor or major types of competitors. They outline competitors' probable solutions and strategies based on their knowledge of the market, the customer, and competitors' prior strategies and capabilities. Figure 21 provides an outline of a Black Hat review.

Organizer	✓ Capture Manager
Team Members	✓ Independent Black Hat leader ✓ Business development management ✓ Experts on competitors ✓ Product/service experts
Other Attendees	✓ Capture manager ✓ Capture team
Documents	✓ Blue Team summary report ✓ Partial capture plan ✓ Bidder Comparison Chart
Possible Approaches	✓ Competitor simulation by teams ✓ Group discussion ✓ Consultant analyses ✓ Capture team analysis

Figure 21. Planning and Executing a Black Hat Review. *Capture managers organize Black Hat reviews to best access intelligence and expertise about competitors. Black Hat Teams generally review more mature documentation than Blue Teams and often incorporate outside personnel. Programmatic inputs are less important because emphasis is placed on what competitors can do rather than your organization's capabilities.*

Conduct multiple Black Hat Team reviews when prompted by major changes in the requirements, competition, or competitors' probable solutions. Conduct simplified Black Hat reviews for smaller competitions.

Conduct a technical Black Hat review as a subset, focused on outlining competitors' baseline solutions in sufficient detail to estimate their probable bid prices.

Figure 22 shows the inputs and outputs of the Black Hat review.

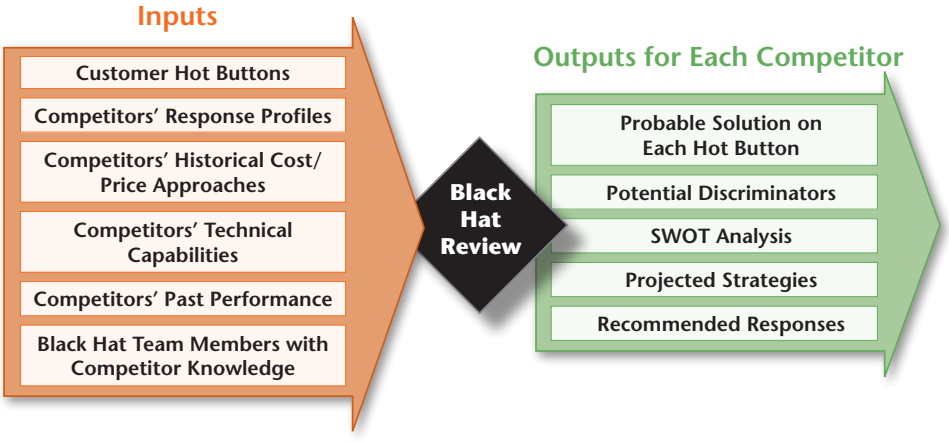


Figure 22. Black Hat Review. *Divide Black Hat review members into teams representing various competitors. Using competitive response profiles, estimate each competitor's most plausible solution to the customer's needs. Ask each team to develop the likely capture plan for the assigned competitor. Form a technical design subset to develop competitors' baseline solutions in sufficient detail to estimate their probable bid prices.*

Black Hat Instructions
Black Hat Planner
Black Hat Review Form

See Color Team Reviews in the *Shipley Capture Guide*.

The ideal Black Hat review outcome is to credibly answer the following types of questions:



How do you shape the game?

What are the competitors' likely strategies?

How do you stack up against the competition in technical capabilities, price, risk, and past performance?

What are the competitors' strengths and weaknesses?

What issues do you ghost?

Whom does the customer prefer?



If you are not the incumbent, how do you unseat them?

If you are the incumbent, how do you retain your position?

How do you become the competitor to beat? Can you achieve a favored position?

How can you counteract the competitors' marketing efforts?

Milestone

- Black Hat Review

3-13 Update capture strategy

Revisit the customer's hot buttons and the probable competitor list and update your capture strategy. Incorporate new competitors; changes in customer perceptions, hot button issues, and requirements; and market and technology shifts.

Update the technical, management, and pricing aspects of your capture strategy. Remember that your price to win is a trade off between price and capability that offers the best value to this customer, as demonstrated in Figure 23.



Figure 23. Deciding on your Price to Win. *Seek a balance of your price and capability and the perceived best value of the customer.*

3-14 Mock up an executive summary

Jump start the proposal effort by developing a mockup of the executive summary. This document is used by senior business development leaders to make a bid/no bid decision. Using the customer-focused approach, align the customer's hot button issues with elements of your solution. If you cannot link an element of your solution to a hot button (HB) issue, eliminate that element or develop a strategy to influence the customer to value that element.

Figure 24 illustrates an effective method for organizing a draft executive summary.

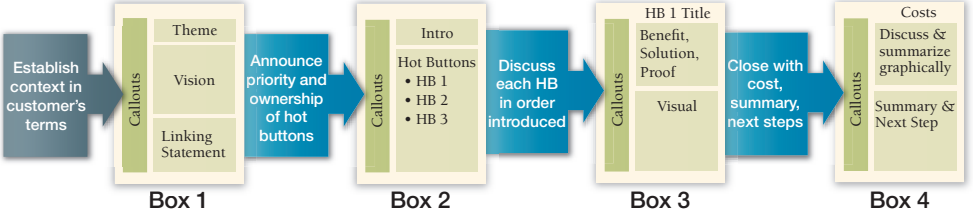


Figure 24. Hot Button Executive Summary. *An executive summary organized according to the customer's hot buttons is a remarkably effective communication tool. Use your executive summary mockup to brief internal management and the subsequent proposal team.*

Using the customer hot button organization places the focus on the customer. Your final proposal executive summary might subsequently be realigned with the evaluation criteria, but the key content and customer focus are retained.

Executive Summary Organizer

3-15 Prepare preliminary bid/no-bid recommendations

The Preliminary Bid Decision Gate review is precipitated by the customer's decision to seek bids.

Predefine Preliminary Bid Decision Gate review inputs and outputs for your organization, but scale and adapt your requirements to the market, selling environment, customer, and competitive situation. Your updated capture plan is sufficient for this review.

Adapt the lists of questions found in Appendix B to your organization and selling environment. Most of these questions should be incorporated in your capture planning template.

3-16 Make preliminary bid/no-bid decision

Your objective for the Preliminary Bid Decision Gate review is to prepare the necessary documents so that senior business development leaders can determine if capture activities have improved your position sufficiently to justify planning and preparing a proposal. Figure 25 features a list of questions to ask as you prepare the bid decision information for senior management.

Invite senior managers who have a stake in the effort due to their management responsibilities, control of resources, market expertise, or service and product expertise. Objectively review the positive and negative aspects of continuing or ending the pursuit. Ground decisions on facts rather than subjective opinions.

Contract Schedule	✓ Do we have a clear understanding of the deliverables and schedule?
Evaluation Process	✓ Are we sure of the evaluation process to be used?
Competition	✓ Do we know the customer's perception of competitors? ✓ Has an objective bidder comparison chart been completed?
Subcontracting	✓ Do we have firm commitments from needed teammates?
Past Performance	✓ Do we have strong, relevant past performance?
Management	✓ Does our management approach provide added value?
Technical	✓ Does our technical solution provide added value or discriminators?
Discriminators, Themes	✓ Are our discriminators unique and important to the customer? ✓ Can the customer justify selecting us based on our discriminators and cost?
Pricing to Win	✓ Has a price to win been determined, and is it acceptable to management?
Opportunity Status	✓ Is the customer adhering to the expected schedule? ✓ If not, why not, and what does that tell us about opportunity?

Figure 25. Preliminary Bid Decision Questions. *Consider these questions when preparing for or attending a preliminary bid decision meeting. Add your own to this checklist whenever they make sense. Delete those that don't apply to your company or market opportunities.*

Refer to Appendix B—Preliminary and Final Bid Decision Gate Review Questions

Milestone

- Preliminary Bid Decision Gate Review

3-17 Designate program/project managers and proposal team

If you decide to advance the opportunity, identify and assign a proposal lead and program/project manager, if not done previously.

Some organizations assign program/project and proposal manager roles to one individual. Occasionally, due to opportunity size or corporate resources, this may be necessary. However, for most large programs, assign different people.

Program/project manager and proposal manager are distinct roles.

The program/project manager is the single individual on the capture team responsible for delivering a successful solution to the customer that results in quality past performance reviews and additional work. The program/project manager is program- and delivery-team focused, frequently reviewing resumes for program personnel; structuring the program organization, functions, and work breakdown structure; resolving teaming relationships and agreements; and coordinating with the customer and subcontractors. The program/project manager needs to be separate in order to be the sanity check on what's going into the proposal.

The proposal manager is focused on proposal development, including maintaining schedules, coordinating inputs, conducting reviews, implementing strategy, and resolving internal problems.

If you delay selecting the program manager, you delay solution development and pricing. When work begins on the proposal before the baseline solution is defined, the solution tends to be marginally compliant, marginally responsive, unpersuasive, generic, and seller focused. Disconnects between different aspects of the solution described in the proposal also impact pricing and risk.

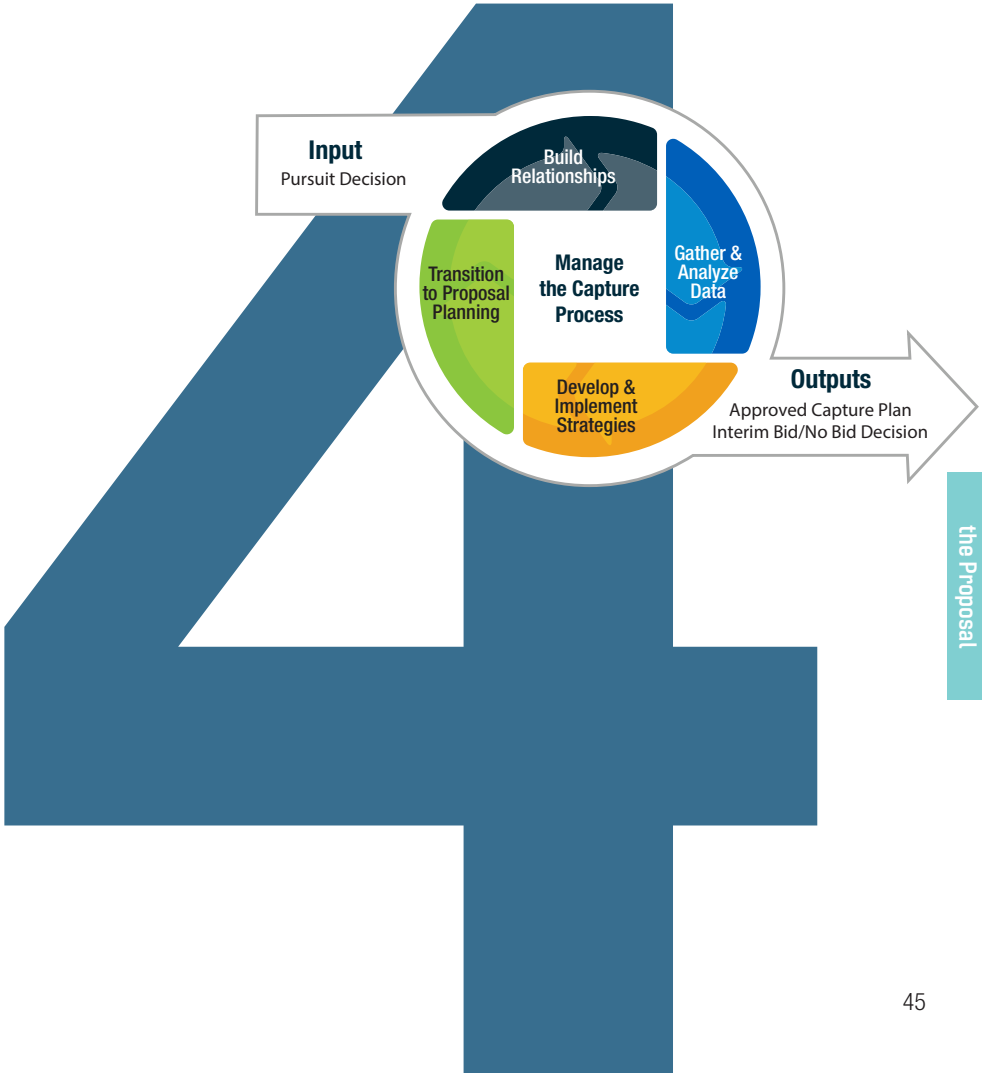
A well-conceived and executed capture plan prepares the proposal team to write a successful proposal. The capture manager's goal is to arrive at final solicitation release in a favored position with the customer; with winning baseline solutions in technical, management, past performance, and cost or price areas; and with confirmation that the capture strategy and proposal strategy are approved and aligned.

Note that when the capture manager engages proposal support, capture planning, proposal planning, and proposal preparation continue in parallel.

Notes:

Supporting the Proposal

The capture manager should provide oversight and information about the opportunity and the customer to help the proposal team develop a winning proposal.



Notes:

4-1 Focus the proposal team on customer needs



The capture manager should provide oversight and continuity until the contract is signed. The capture manager's role is to help focus the proposal team on the customer's needs and maintain continuity in the process.

Good capture management sets the company up for both successful proposal development and contract execution.

The more connectivity and alignment between the capture/opportunity manager and the proposal team, the better. Too often, a sales or capture lead will completely "hand off" the opportunity to the proposal team. This slows progress and weakens your Pwin.

See Engaging Program Management and Engaging Proposal Support in the *Shipley Capture Guide*.

4-2 Align capture plan to support proposal plan

Proposal planning can proceed in many directions, depending on the personnel assigned, their locations and experience levels, or preferences of the proposal manager. Corporate policies may also dictate the formality of proposal planning. In some cases, it's useful to collect a range of planning and background information under a single cover as a proposal plan or proposal management plan, as shown in Figure 26.

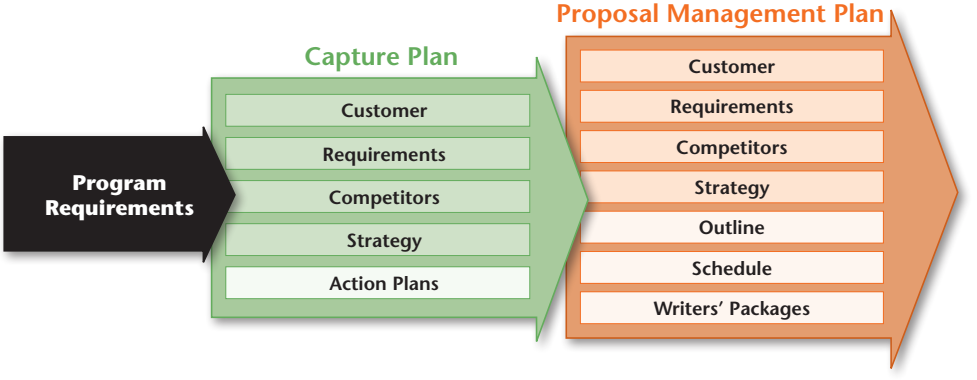


Figure 26. Capture Plan Transition. *For large proposals, or when there are many teaming partners, the proposal manager may decide to collect essential planning documents under a single file. In such cases, much of the background information from the capture plan can be reused. The proposal manager adds proposal-specific information such as the outline, schedule, and individual writer's instruction packages.*

Don't make others work any harder than necessary. The capture plan will already contain the background information on the customer, the opportunity, and competitors the proposal team needs to consider. The capture strategies should pass directly to the proposal manager to be converted into proposal strategies, but with the capture manager's help.

The capture team should know the customer. The proposal team may not. The capture manager is responsible for transferring knowledge of the customer to the rest of the team.

4-3 Contribute to the proposal kickoff

The capture manager should play a prominent role in the proposal kickoff meeting. Figure 27 summarizes the key agenda items of an effective proposal kickoff. The proposal manager normally runs the meeting but asks the capture manager to brief the team where appropriate.

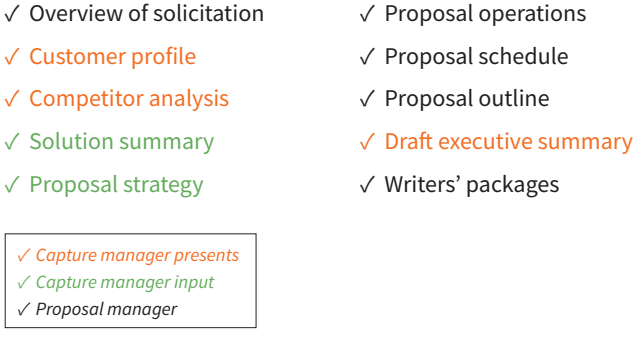


Figure 27. Kickoff Agenda Responsibilities. *Since many proposal team members know little about the opportunity, the capture manager can help by presenting customer and competitor information and presenting or providing input to the solution summary and proposal strategy topics. The capture manager should also present the draft executive summary, which lets proposal team members know the story they should tell.*

Providing the solicitation overview at kickoff normally belongs to the proposal manager, who is establishing tone, direction, and control of the team. The customer profile and competitor analysis, which proposal authors need to write persuasive sections, is usually presented by the capture manager. Those items are shown in Figure 27 in orange.

The solution summary and proposal strategy may be delivered by the technical manager and the proposal manager, respectively, but the capture manager has a lot of input to those topics. Depending on the circumstances, the capture manager may present them. The deciding factor is who can best transfer knowledge to the proposal team.

Operations, schedule, and outline are the purview of the proposal manager, as are the written instructions to authors in the writers' packages. But the draft executive summary should be presented by the capture manager who wrote it to incorporate the tone of previous customer exchanges as closely as possible.

See Kickoff Meetings in the *Shipley Proposal Guide*.

4-4 Participate in proposal reviews

Capture managers should continue to support the proposal process by participating in proposal reviews. Since the capture manager has had the most contact with the customer and opportunity, they can provide significant feedback to help create a winning proposal.

The proposal team's most powerful review is from the Pink Team. It conducts an essential strategic review to confirm that the proposal will successfully execute the organization's win strategy. The capture manager provides context for Pink Team members who may not be familiar with the customer. Figure 28 illustrates the inputs and outputs of a Pink Team review.

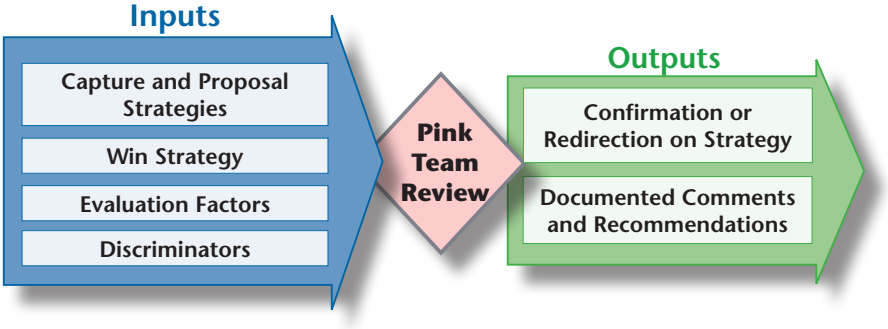


Figure 28. Pink Team Inputs and Outputs. *The Pink Team determines whether the proposal is on track, preferably before authors spend time writing text. The capture manager can prevent authors from writing with improper emphasis, or even about the wrong topics.*

After the proposal team develops the full proposal, they submit it for a Red Team review. The Red Team has two major purposes: predicting how the proposal will score against the customer's evaluation factors and assessing proposal quality. To ensure customer focus, the capture manager should help with the qualitative assessment, as shown in Figure 29.

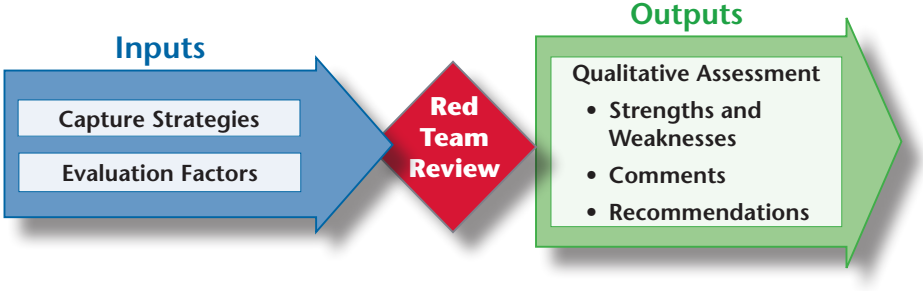


Figure 29. Red Team Inputs and Outputs. *The Red Team offers the last chance to improve a proposal's strategic impact before delivery.*

Final proposal revision (FPR) submittal and evaluation are the last stages before source selection. Especially at this final, critical stage, the capture manager makes important contributions. Figure 30 shows these contributions in the revision process.

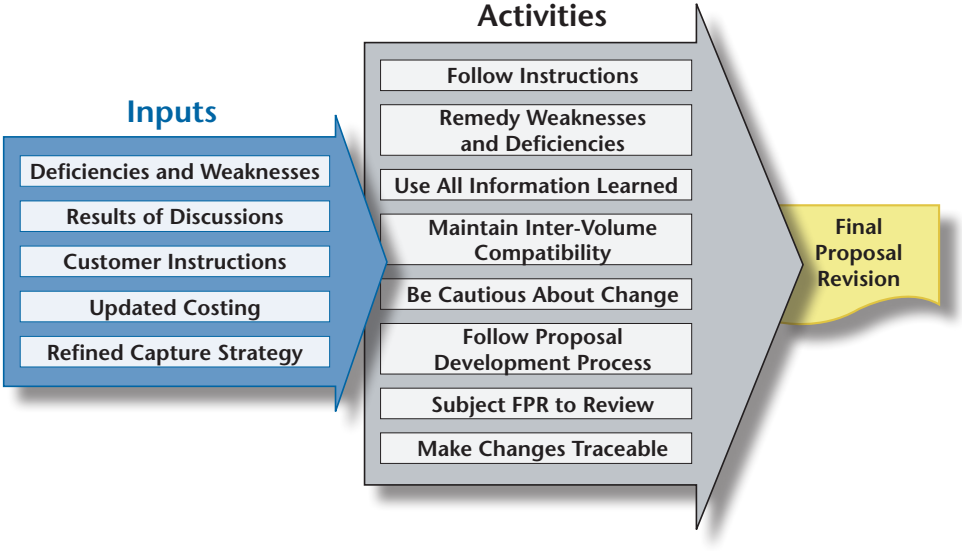


Figure 30. Capture Manager Supports the FPR. *The FPR comes at a point when the capture manager knows more about the customer and opportunity than at any other time because of exchanges that have occurred in response to proposal submission. Many guesses and estimates have been confirmed or disproven. There is explicit feedback on the proposed solution and price. This is the time to be exceptionally careful modifying the proposal. The capture manager's perspective is vital.*

4-5 Contribute to customer debriefs and White Hat review

The capture manager should still contribute to post-bid submittal interactions as much as possible. If the capture manager will have the primary ongoing relationship with the customer, he or she may stay involved after the bid has been submitted. When someone else holds the primary relationship with the customer, senior management will assign the capture manager to another pursuit.

Proposal debriefs are important meetings to review how effectively a proposal worked or didn't work. These are usually facilitated by the capture manager or proposal manager. Win or lose, request a debrief. The capture manager should focus on listening, recognizing non-verbal signals, and asking constructive follow-up questions.

Add the input from your debrief to the White Hat review, where you review from both internal and external perspectives ways that future pursuits can be more successful. The capture manager should organize a White Hat review with the proposal manager. The goal of a White Hat review is shown in Figure 31.

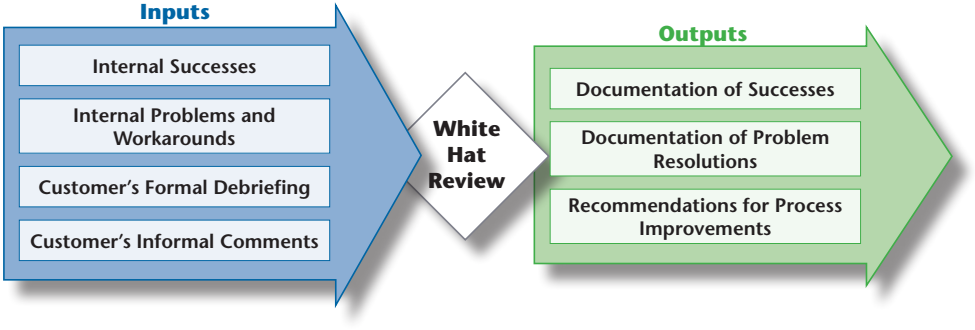


Figure 31. White Hat Inputs and Outputs. *Internal inputs on both successes and problems and their workarounds come from members of the capture and proposal teams after their efforts are essentially complete. External feedback, both formal and informal, comes from customers. All available information should be honestly assessed for understanding. The White Hat review members should develop recommendations, including steps and activities to continue and methods or approaches to change.*

Milestone

- White Hat Review

Tools and Templates

Appendix A—Interest Decision Gate Review and Business Intelligence Questions

- What type of project/program is it?
- Is it real?
- Has the program/project been budgeted?
- Does the customer have budget cuts looming on the horizon?
- Does the customer have a history of project cancellations?
- Has the customer ever sent out feeler solicitations, RFIs, or tenders? Are in-house customer organizations potential competitors?
- What is our history with this customer?
- Will the customer specify the type of bidders (for example, disadvantaged, minority, or small-business requirement)?
- Who is the customer's program/project manager?
- Who are the evaluators?
- Do we have any biases to overcome?
- Are there any legislative or regulatory issues regarding this program? Would organizational conflict of interest issues preclude pursuing this opportunity for a future, larger, and more strategic opportunity?
- What is the budget? What portion of the budget is typically held back for management overhead, risks, or other factors? What is the probable price to compete?
- Is the customer cost-sensitive?
- Is there an incumbent?
- Have the competitors had problems with overruns?
- Is cost or capability a more important consideration in awarding the contract?
- If this procurement is a U.S. government "best value" award, will it be under the Lowest Price Technically Acceptable (LPTA) or other trade-off process definitions and guidelines?

Appendix B—Preliminary and Final Bid Decision Gate Review Questions

Assess the customer

- What agencies or departments are involved in the buying process? Who are the main contacts?
- Are they reliable? Do you like to do business with them? Do they like to do business with you?
- How does the customer view the incumbent, if one exists?
- What are the parts, phases, and sequences involved in the procurement?
- How have you been involved in and influenced customer objectives, requirements, or specifications? Who is involved? How?
- Who are the key decision makers and influencers? Who are the key people in other agencies, government bodies, consulting organizations, or industry locations?
- What are the internal customer politics, policies, or biases that might influence requirements and selection decisions?
- What else do you need to know about this customer and this procurement?
- What is the need that is causing the customer to seek a solution? What value does the customer place on solving or alleviating this need?

Assess capabilities and objectives

- Why do you want this business?
- Is this procurement in line with the business plans and with your projections?
- Do you have the physical resources and capability to pursue it and to handle the job if you win? What more might be required? Can you bid it and make money? If not, is there still a compelling reason to bid?
- Who are your key management, technical, and other personnel? Are they available? Are they known and liked by this customer?
- What unique or special advantages do you bring to such a procurement?
- What teaming or contracting arrangements might be required? Are such arrangements practical?
- What is your track record on similar activities with this customer? With similar customers?
- Who might be your program manager?
- On what strengths would you win this procurement? On what weaknesses might you lose it?
- How have you influenced the operational requirements or project/design requirements?

Assess the competitors

- Who is the incumbent?
- Who might be competitors?
- Can you team to preempt a formidable competitor team?
- Who has a history of successful work with this customer? Can you compete?
- What are the strengths and weaknesses of each of your competitors?
- What are the traditional bidding/pricing practices for each of your competitors? When they win, what is the key factor? What prior successful pricing and solutioning strategies are they likely to repeat?
- What are the long-term competitive implications for the winners and losers of this bid?
- What are the political forces now operating or surrounding this procurement? Are you in a politically favorable position to win? Is someone else?
- What public relations, advertising, and promotion work might be needed to highlight your strengths and overcome competitors' strengths?

Assess the financial opportunity

- What is the dollar value of the procurement? Who knows this information?
- What profits/benefits can you expect? Have you prepared a business case?
- Do you gain some long-term capability/capacity that will position your organization for future earnings?
- How does this customer typically structure their buys?
- How do they conduct procurements? What are their contracting practices?
- Does the funding exist? Are different types of funds budgeted, such as capital versus operating costs? What is the timing? What will be required for the funding to be allocated? Will the funding stay in place over the life of the project?
- Do you have the business development money to pursue it?
- Can you meet the customer's requirements? At what cost?
- What is your chance of winning? What would it cost you to win?
- On what basis (cost) will the procurement be won or lost? Are you strong here? How about your competition?
- Will the customer require warranties? Offsets? Investments? Performance bonds? Liquidated damages?
- Is payment subject to revenues generated?

Define the opportunity

- Exactly what is the customer requesting at this time? How firm is this?
- What is the scope of the project at this time? Will it change?
- What is the time period for the procurement? For the project? Is this typical? Reasonable?
- How does this fit into your long-term business plan?
- What are the procurement terms and requirements? What is typical for this customer?
- What office and person are leading the effort for the customer? Can you work compatibly with them over the life of the contract?
- Will it happen as projected? What is your experience?
- When will the bid request be issued?
- When will the procurement begin and end?
- Can you meet the requirements now, without major retooling, hiring, or change? How significant are those requirements you cannot meet now?

The Capture Manager Tools

Capture Workbook

- Probability Calculator
- Bidder Comparison Chart
- Action Plan Template

Integrated Solution Worksheet

Customer Meeting Planning Form

Executive Summary Organizer

Capture Plan Template

Opportunity Planner Template

Black Hat

- Black Hat Instructions
- Black Hat Planner
- Black Hat Review Form

Blue Team

- Blue Team Instructions
- Blue Team Planner
- Blue Team Review Form
- Blue Team Assessment Form

Glossary of Terms

TERM	DESCRIPTION
Action Plans	Specific tasks with deadlines assigned to individuals or teams during the capture phase of business development. Generally, action plans are kept and tracked in an action plan log.
Bid Decisions	Bid decisions are used to eliminate opportunities with a low win probability so a business devotes stronger focus on opportunities with a high win probability.
Bidder Comparison Chart	An Excel tool to assess and compare your capabilities compared to competitors' capabilities, based on customer issues or requirements.
Black Hat Review	A review to determine competitors' likely strategies and solutions.
Blue Team Review	A review scheduled early in the capture plan where reviewers validate the win strategy and required actions in the capture plan.
Capture Manager (Opportunity)	Also referred to as opportunity manager, sales lead, or pursuit manager. This person is designated to lead the sales effort on a specific opportunity—often working closely with a proposal team throughout the process.
Capture Plan	Envision the capture plan as a framework, a series of folders or buckets where you assemble and organize data by topic. As you conduct sales and capture activities, update the content in the folders based on things to do and learn about the sales environment.
Capture Strategy	Strategies and actions implemented after a positive Blue Hat review to win the opportunity.
Color Team Reviews	Reviews throughout the business development lifecycle that increase your probability of winning and support capture planning and proposal development milestones.
Competitive Analysis	Comparing your offer with your competition. Often this analysis is done using a tool, such as a bidder comparison matrix.
Customer	The target of your sales messages and recipient of your proposal or solicitation response.
Decision Gate	Key milestones in the business development process, triggered by predefined customer actions (such as issuance of a bid request), at which time senior management decides whether to continue the pursuit and invest in competing or end the pursuit.
Discriminator	A feature or benefit of your solution that is important and valuable to the customer, and unique to your company.
Executive Summary	The section of a proposal that acts as an overview for the entire document. An effective executive summary highlights the key hot buttons for a customer.

TERM	DESCRIPTION
Ghosting	Highlighting a competitor's weakness or downplaying a competitor's strengths without naming the competitor.
Hot Buttons	A consolidated set of customer issues and motivators for issuing a request for bid. Issues are the customer's concerns or worry items. Motivators are the objectives that the customer is trying to achieve. Hot buttons are typically a subset of both these groupings.
Kickoff Meeting	A proposal kickoff meeting establishes a clear plan for integrating capture strategies with proposal strategies. Proposal team roles are also assigned.
Program/Project Manager	A person who leads the actual implementation or execution of contract deliverables after the contract is awarded.
Proposal Management Plan	A plan that details the processes for managing a successful team to develop and deliver a winning proposal.
Proposal Team	The proposal team contains the proposal manager and his or her selected proposal writers. They are responsible for proposal development. The capture manager should offer their knowledge of the customer throughout the proposal development process to ensure the proposal is customer focused.
Pwin	Probability of Win. Pwin is a representative number or percentage based on win factor ratings that help determine the likelihood of winning a specific business opportunity. Pwin is used in conjunction with other means of research and analysis to evaluate business opportunities and includes an assessment of the competitive position.
Price-to-win	A process where a business analyzes competitor and customer data to determine a winning offer price and how to present that price to the customer.
Solicitation	A generic term for the bid request, Request for Proposal, grant request, or any guidance document or information on how to bid for work with a customer.
SWOT	Strengths, weaknesses, opportunities, and threats. An analysis to gauge your position in an opportunity compared to competitors.
Value Proposition	A customer-focused statement in a proposal addressing how parts of an offer will positively affect the customer's business.
White Hat Review	Also referred to as lessons learned review. A review to assess the proposal development process and results to improve future projects. Conducted after the proposal has been completed.
Work Breakdown Structure	A deliverable way to organize groups of elements that defines the total scope of the project work.

Notes:

Notes:

ShipleyAssociates®

About Shipley

Since 1972, Shipley Associates has provided organizations and individuals with business development services focused on winning business in highly competitive environments. With over 320 consultants worldwide, Shipley supports major business development projects from strategy development, capture planning, proposal development, process improvement, and web-based and classroom learning—resulting in an average client win rate of over 83 percent.

Shipley has international offices in over 12 countries. For more information, visit our website www.shipleywins.com.

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The *Shipley Proposal Guide* contains 52 topics and 12 model documents. Each topic section provides a summary of key points.

Organized around 20 topics, the *Shipley Capture Guide* provides tools and templates to help organizations win business in varied selling environments.

The *Business Development Lifecycle Guide* provides a comprehensive, baseline lifecycle for competing and winning in strategic markets.

The Shipley *Proposal Manager Playbook* is a step-by-step guide that helps Proposal Managers effectively lead a proposal team in planning and developing a winning proposal and conducting post-submittal activities.



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